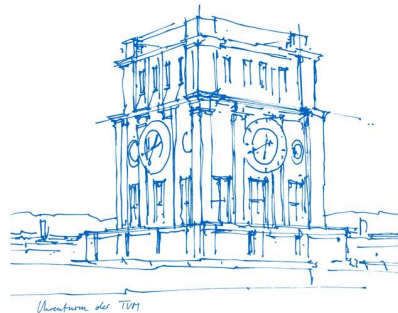


PoreAccess-CO₂: From Random Packing to an Interpretable Transport Closure

Structure-resolved diffusion and adsorption in DEM-generated zeolite beds

Technical University of Munich
Chair of Process Systems Engineering

Ali Khalifa & Heiko Briesen



2026-09-23

Welcome everybody, and thank you for attending my presentation. Before I start, one short note about the slides: they were not designed or optimized as conference or workshop slides. You will notice that some of them are relatively dense and contain more equations than I would normally use in that setting. The reason is that I am currently using this deck to iterate the research idea and its technical details together with Heiko, so I want the assumptions, equations, and modelling steps to remain explicit rather than overly abstract. Today, I would like to talk about a recent project that I have been working on together with Heiko. The general idea of this work is to investigate how the geometry of a randomly packed bed can inform a reduced model of transient adsorption. As an application example, we consider CO₂ adsorption in packed beds of zeolite particles.



Presentation outline

Motivation and research question

Pore-network reference model

Reduction and diffusivity prediction

Results and robustness

Conclusions and next steps

Let me briefly outline the presentation. I will first motivate why we are interested in the structure of the packed bed, and in particular in the inlet accessibility dictated by the arrangement of particles near the inlet. From this, I will formulate the main research question. Then I will briefly introduce the pore-network model that we use to simulate transport and adsorption in the individual packings and to obtain the mean uptake of the bed over time. In the next step, we will reduce these geometrically complex beds to homogeneous one-dimensional beds and investigate how an effective diffusivity can be used as a closure for the influence of the underlying structure. Finally, I will show the results and summarize the main conclusions.

Section 1 of 5

Motivation and research question

Why should inlet-connected pathways matter?

So, why should inlet pathways matter? The gas has to enter the packing through connected pore pathways, and their accessibility depends on the local particle arrangement.

└ Motivation and research question

└ Why examine access from the inlet?

Why examine access from the inlet?

What porosity misses

- Porosity measures how much void space exists.
- It does not describe bottlenecks, path lengths or parallel connections.
- Similar void fractions can therefore hide different gas-supply pathways.

Application: CO₂ adsorption in zeolite 13X, used here as a controlled model problem.

Hypothesis: inlet-connected diffusive pathways contain information that porosity misses.

Why the inlet is the reference

- Gas enters from a reservoir below the bed.
- Adsorption removes gas as it diffuses into the packing.
- Access from the inlet may therefore help explain transient uptake differences.

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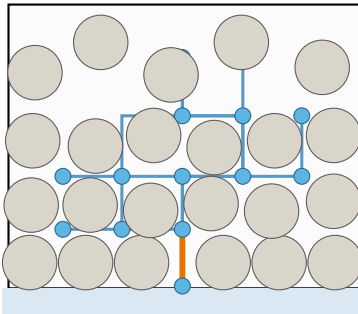
- Gas enters from a reservoir below the bed.
- Adsorption removes gas as it diffuses into the packing.
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In other words, why should we care specifically about accessibility from the inlet? Packed-bed adsorption models typically use porosity as one of the main structural descriptors. Porosity tells us how much void space is available, but it does not tell us how this void space is connected. For example, it does not describe bottlenecks, path lengths, or the number of parallel pathways through which the gas can move. So two beds with very similar porosities can still provide quite different gas-supply pathways. In applications such as CO₂ adsorption, the gas enters the packed bed from a reservoir at the bottom. This makes the inlet a physically meaningful reference boundary. At the same time, adsorption continuously removes CO₂ from the gas phase as the gas diffuses through the packing. So the ability to supply gas from the inlet toward the interior may become important for the transient response. This motivates us to test inlet-to-interior accessibility as an additional structural descriptor. And I want to emphasize that this is a hypothesis that we are testing. We are not claiming that the inlet structure alone controls all adsorption time scales. CO₂ adsorption in zeolite provides us with a controlled application in which we can investigate this question.

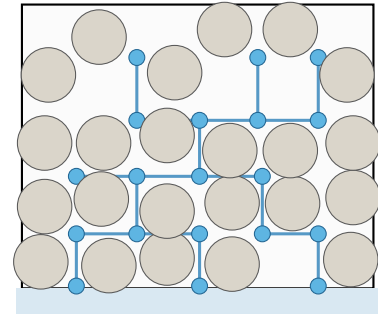
Same porosity can hide different inlet-connected pathways

Can a pore-accessibility measure predict bed-scale transient transport better than porosity alone?

Packing A: inlet bottleneck



Packing B: multiple inlet paths



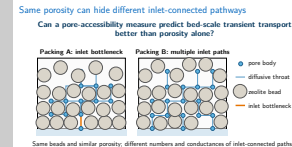
- pore body
- diffusive throat
- zeolite bead
- inlet bottleneck

Same beads and similar porosity; different numbers and conductances of inlet-connected paths.

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└ Motivation and research question

└ Same porosity can hide different inlet-connected pathways



This schematic introduces the central problem. The two beds contain the same monodisperse beads and can have almost the same total porosity. Their inlet-connected paths can nevertheless differ strongly. Packing A illustrates a network reached through one restrictive inlet bottleneck. Packing B illustrates several paths that connect the reservoir to the bed interior.

The blue lines show only simplified inlet-connected paths, not every throat in a real extracted network. The sketches are therefore hypotheses rather than simulation results. They motivate our research question: can a quantitative pore-accessibility measure predict transient bed-scale transport better than bulk porosity alone?

Section 2 of 5

Pore-network reference model

From particle geometry to the mean uptake curve

From particle geometry to the mean uptake curve.

Twenty beds isolate variability caused by random arrangement



Quantity	Fixed value
beads per bed	1850
bead diameter	1.6 mm
tube diameter	16 mm
D_{tube}/d_p	10
inlet c_{CO_2}	6.05 mol m^{-3}
simulation time	5000 s

Controlled diffusion–adsorption problem

- 20 beds generated by LAMMPS DEM: gravity pouring followed by damped settling
- same beads, tube and filling protocol; only the insertion seed changes
- dry, isothermal diffusion–adsorption; gas supplied from below, no imposed flow
- no heat effects or competitive water adsorption

$c_{\text{in}} = y_{\text{CO}_2} p / (RT) \approx 6.05 \text{ mol m}^{-3}$ at 15 vol.%, 1 bar and 298 K.
15% represents coal-combustion flue gas (typical CO₂: 10–15%).
A dry, cooled reference gas fixes the driving concentration across all beds.
Source: U.S. DOE, Quadrennial Technology Review (2015), Sec. 4.E.

The ensemble tests arrangement effects under otherwise identical conditions.

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- └ Pore-network reference model
- └ Twenty beds isolate variability caused by random arrangement

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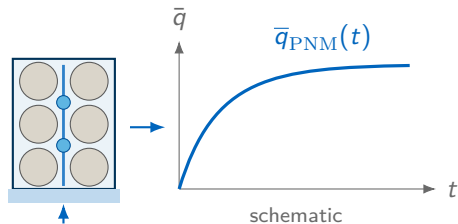
The ensemble tests arrangement effects under otherwise identical conditions.

We generate twenty beds using LAMMPS discrete-element simulations. The fix pour command inserts beads above the bed, and gravity fills the cylindrical tube. After insertion, damped settling brings the packing to rest. The beads, tube and filling procedure stay fixed; only the insertion seed changes. Because the bed has a free upper surface, the final bed height is not prescribed; it is an outcome of the random settling process. The cross-sectional area and total solid volume are fixed, but slightly different final bed heights give slightly different bed volumes and therefore slightly different porosities, even though every case uses the same number of monodisperse particles. The inlet value corresponds to a CO2 mole fraction of approximately 15 percent at one bar: c equals y times p divided by RT. The DOE report gives a typical coal-combustion flue-gas range of 10 to 15 percent CO2, which motivates this representative concentration. Temperature is held at 298.15 K and the gas is dry, so this is a cooled, simplified reference condition. We do not simulate hot, wet industrial flue gas or its other constituents. Keeping the same reservoir concentration for all twenty beds isolates arrangement effects. The cited concentration range motivates the boundary condition, not a claim of industrial process

Pore-network model: the uptake reference

A reference curve for each bed

Coupled diffusion and uptake



Identical beads:

$$\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t) = \frac{1}{N_b} \sum_{k=1}^{N_b} q_k(t).$$

One coupled system: one concentration per pore, one loading per bead.

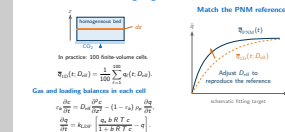
The PNM is the structure-resolved numerical reference for each bed. It retains the actual pore connections and solves gas diffusion and bead adsorption as one coupled system: one gas concentration per pore and one loading per bead. Averaging the loadings of the identical beads gives $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$, the full transient reference curve used to fit the reduced model. The drawing is schematic, not simulation data. Detailed construction, balances and isotherm definitions are retained in the PNM appendix.

Section 3 of 5

Reduction and diffusivity prediction

Fit a reduced model, then predict its coefficient

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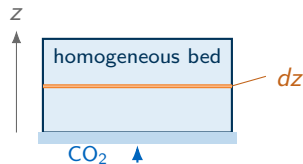
Gas and loading balances in each cell

$$\varepsilon_b \frac{\partial c}{\partial t} = D_{eff} \frac{\partial^2 c}{\partial z^2} - (1 - \varepsilon_b) \rho_p \frac{\partial q}{\partial t},$$

$$\frac{\partial q}{\partial t} = k_{LDF} \left[\frac{q_s b R T c}{1 + b R T c} - q \right].$$

We replace the detailed network by a homogeneous bed with 100 equal finite-volume cells, each spanning the full tube cross-section. The thin band illustrates a differential control volume; the displayed continuum balances are discretized on those cells to solve one gas concentration and one loading per cell. Equal cell volumes and uniform adsorbent density make the bed-average loading the arithmetic mean shown here. We keep the bed geometry, porosity, inlet condition, isotherm and kinetics fixed and adjust the single effective diffusivity to reproduce the full PNM uptake history for that bed. The curves illustrate the fitting target, not measured data or a sequence of optimization trials. The detailed model slides remain in the 1D appendix.

Reduced 1D model and fitting target



In practice: 100 finite-volume cells.

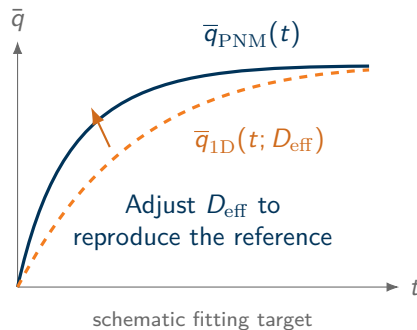
$$\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D_{eff}) = \frac{1}{100} \sum_{\ell=1}^{100} q_{\ell}(t; D_{eff}).$$

Gas and loading balances in each cell

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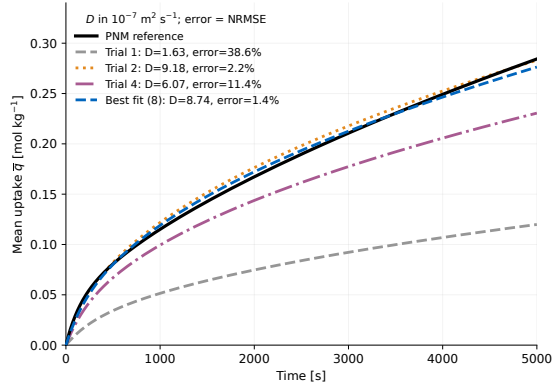
$$\frac{\partial q}{\partial t} = k_{LDF} \left[\frac{q_s b R T c}{1 + b R T c} - q \right].$$

Match the PNM reference



Fit the effective diffusivity to the complete uptake curve

Actual optimization trials: bed 18427



Selected evaluations in recorded order; individual trials need not improve the fit.

Curve error and fitted coefficient

$$e_m(D) = \bar{q}_{1D}(t_m; D) - \bar{q}_{PNM}(t_m).$$

$$\text{NRMSE}(D) = \frac{\sqrt{\sum_m w_m e_m(D)^2}}{\bar{q}_{PNM}(t_f)},$$

$$\sum_m w_m = 1.$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = \arg \min_D \text{NRMSE}(D).$$

Time weights account for unequal output spacing.

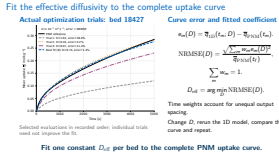
Change D , rerun the 1D model, compare the curve and repeat.

Fit one constant D_{eff} per bed to the complete PNM uptake curve.

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Reduction and diffusivity prediction

Fit the effective diffusivity to the complete uptake curve



The plot shows the PNM curve in black and actual recorded trials 1, 2, 4 and 8 for bed 18427.

The first trial underpredicts uptake, with 38.6 percent error. Trial 2 is already close, but the optimizer explores another value at trial 4 before converging. Trial 8 is the best fit, with D equal to 8.742 times 10^{-7} square metres per second and 1.41 percent error. Trial numbers denote objective evaluations, not time steps. Each curve uses one constant D throughout the simulation. For each bed, we repeatedly solve the homogeneous model with different diffusivities. The search range is 10^{-8} to $1.5 \times 10^{-5} \text{ m}^2 \text{ s}^{-1}$. The upper bound is oriented by the molecular diffusivity of CO₂ in the gas, while the lower bound extends the search by a little more than three orders of magnitude to allow for a strong reduction of effective transport by tortuosity and constrictions. NRMSE means normalized root-mean-square error. Here we weight squared errors by elapsed time using trapezoidal weights, take the square root and divide by the final reference loading. This prevents densely saved times from dominating the fit. These comparison times are deliberately saved on a logarithmic grid, so early transients are sampled more densely. This output-time grid is separate from the BDF solver's internal adaptive time steps, which

Can inlet conductance predict the fitted diffusivity?

Calculate steady inlet access

- Use the pore network with adsorption disabled.
- Fix concentrations at the inlet and an interior plane.
- Solve steady diffusion and sum the molar flux $\dot{n}$.

$$G_{\text{access}} = \frac{\dot{n}}{\Delta c} \quad [\text{m}^3/\text{s}].$$

Conductance measures how much gas the inlet-connected pathways can supply per concentration difference.

One steady conductance calculation supplies the input for transient prediction.

Calibrate the transport coefficient

- Pair each calculated G_{access} with its fitted D_{eff} .
- Fit $D_{\text{eff}} = f(G_{\text{access}})$ on training beds.
- Predict the omitted bed's diffusivity.
- Run its 1D model and compare the complete uptake curve.

└ Reduction and diffusivity prediction

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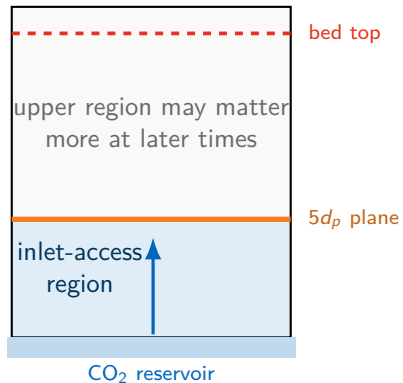
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G access is calculated from a steady diffusion solve on the network, not predicted. Total molar flux divided by the imposed concentration difference has units of cubic metres per second. We use this conductance directly as the descriptor. A relationship learned from other beds maps it to the effective diffusivity in the transient 1D model. Conductance can also correlate with final uptake, but here its target is the coefficient fitted to the complete uptake history. For validation we first predict the omitted bed diffusivity and then run its 1D model without fitting to that bed history. The optional normalization appendix presents the alternative descriptor.

Why use an interior plane?



A plane at $5d_p$ includes

- the inlet openings
- second-layer and deeper bottlenecks
- parallel paths connecting inlet to the plane

The bed top answers a different question

- measure conductance through the entire bed
- include upper bottlenecks that may matter more at later times

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└ Reduction and diffusivity prediction

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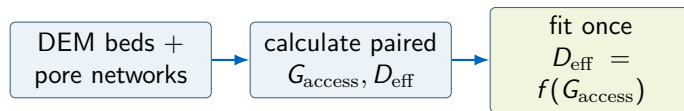
The plane provides a tunable spatial scale for the accessibility diagnostic. A near-inlet plane includes the entrance openings and some deeper constrictions and parallel paths. Using the bed top instead measures conductance through the complete network. The focus on a near-inlet region is motivated by entry-driven uptake, but it does not establish that upper pores are irrelevant at early times. In the current implementation, depth is measured above the lowest retained pore. Five bead diameters is the selected diagnostic depth. The results also compare three, seven and ten bead diameters to examine sensitivity.

└ Reduction and diffusivity prediction

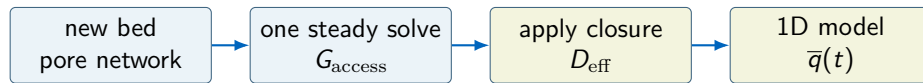
└ Development and later use are two different workflows

Development and later use are two different workflows

Develop closure

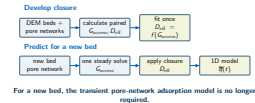


Predict for a new bed



For a new bed, the transient pore-network adsorption model is no longer required.

During development each bed contributes a steady calculated inlet conductance and an effective diffusivity fitted to its complete transient PNM uptake curve. We calibrate the relation between them. For a new bed we calculate its steady conductance, predict its diffusivity, and run the inexpensive 1D transient model. The new bed still requires geometric quantities such as height and porosity for that model, but no transient PNM uptake solve is required for prediction. Held-out evaluation uses the PNM curve only afterwards to assess error.



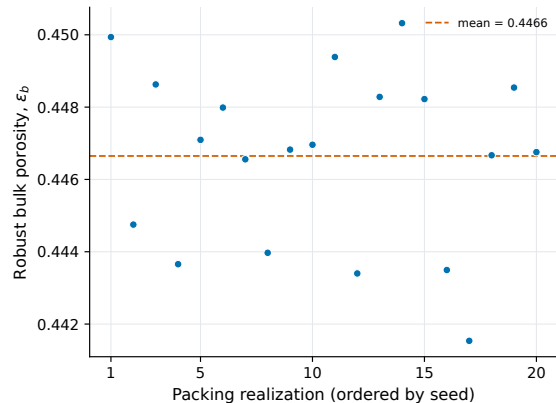
Section 4 of 5

Results and robustness

Test the physical hypothesis and the model reduction

Test the physical hypothesis and the model reduction.

The twenty beds have nearly equal bulk porosity



Bulk-porosity CV: 0.55%.

Controlled ensemble

- same bead count and diameter
- same tube geometry
- only the insertion seed changes

CV: coefficient of variation

$$CV_{\epsilon} = s_{\epsilon} / \bar{\epsilon}$$

s_{ϵ} : standard deviation

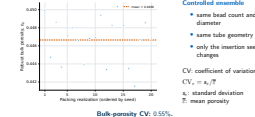
$\bar{\epsilon}$: mean porosity

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Results and robustness

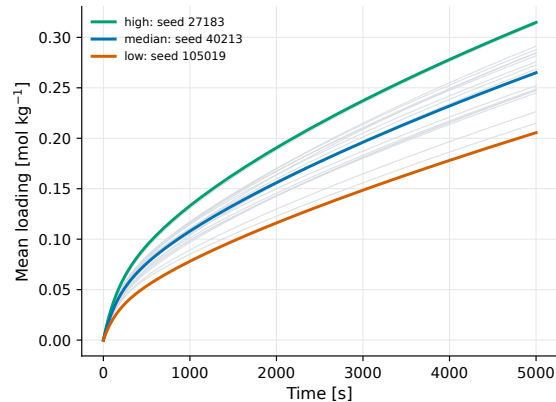
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The twenty beds have nearly equal bulk porosity



The mean bulk porosity is approximately 0.44665. Divide the sample standard deviation by this mean to obtain the coefficient of variation, 0.55 percent. The horizontal axis orders beds by their insertion seed. The small spread establishes the controlled comparison.

Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves



At 5000 s: 0.206–0.315 mol kg⁻¹, with an uptake CV of 11.0%.

Network reference

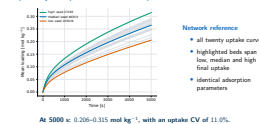
- all twenty uptake curves
- highlighted beds span low, median and high final uptake
- identical adsorption parameters

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Results and robustness

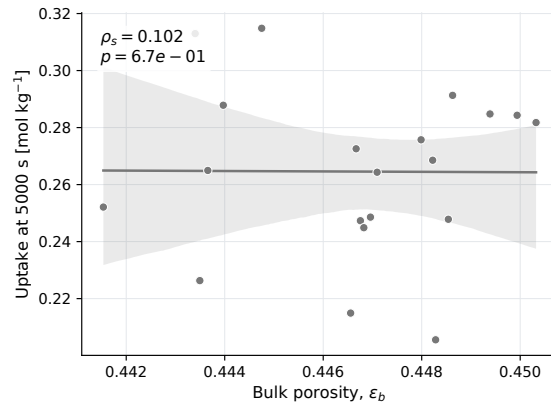
Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves

Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves



The pale curves show the full ensemble. Orange, blue and green identify low, median and high final uptake. These representative beds are selected by final uptake, not by accessibility. The uptake varies much more strongly than porosity.

Bulk porosity alone does not explain final uptake



Porosity baseline

- each point represents one bed
- weak rank association
- wide uncertainty around the fitted relationship

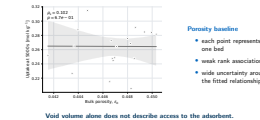
Void volume alone does not describe access to the adsorbent.

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Results and robustness

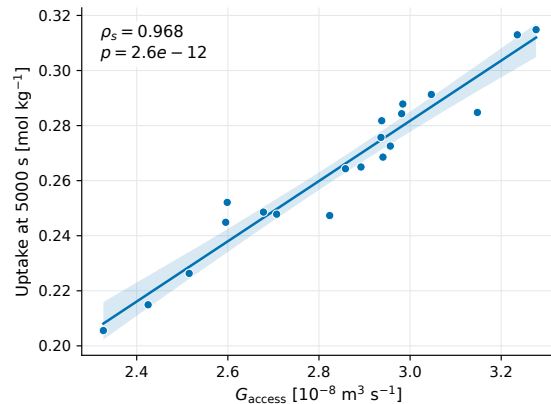
Bulk porosity alone does not explain final uptake

Bulk porosity alone does not explain final uptake



The plot compares bulk porosity with mean loading at 5000 seconds. Spearman correlation is approximately 0.102. The shaded band is pointwise bootstrap uncertainty in the fitted relationship, not a prediction interval for a new bed.

Accessibility explains differences in final uptake



Inlet-connected pathways explain variability that porosity misses.

Steady network descriptor

- G_{access} measures inlet-to-interior conductance
- greater conductance accompanies greater uptake

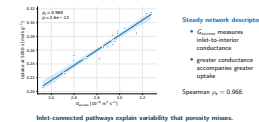
Spearman $\rho_s = 0.968$.

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Results and robustness

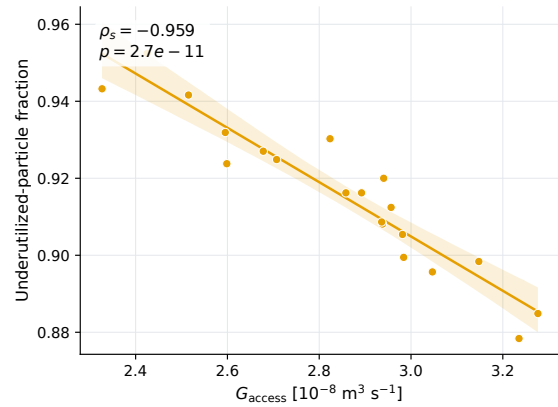
Accessibility explains differences in final uptake

Accessibility explains differences in final uptake



We calculate accessibility using a steady diffusion problem without adsorption. The Spearman coefficient is 0.968. More accessible beds generally have greater uptake. This is a within-ensemble association. The shaded band represents uncertainty in the fitted relationship.

Greater accessibility reduces particle underutilization



Higher G_{access} accompanies fewer underutilized particles.

Underutilized fraction

$$f_{\text{under}} = \frac{1}{N_p} \sum_{k=1}^{N_p} I_k.$$

$I_k = 1$ when

$$q_k(t_f) < 0.5q^*(p_{\text{inlet}}).$$

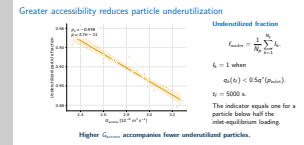
$t_f = 5000 \text{ s}.$

The indicator equals one for a particle below half the inlet-equilibrium loading.

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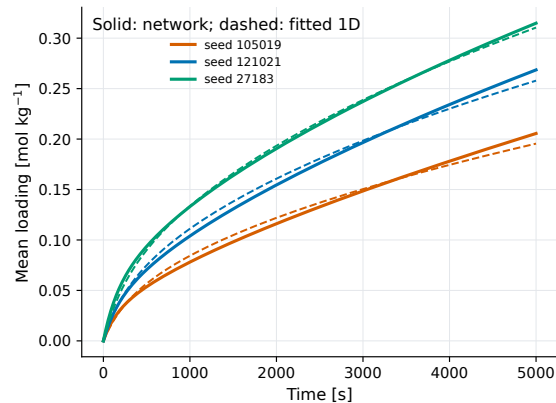
Results and robustness

Greater accessibility reduces particle underutilization



For each bead we compare its final loading with half the equilibrium loading at the inlet pressure. The indicator is one below this threshold and zero otherwise. Averaging over particles gives the plotted fraction. This is a threshold-based utilization measure, not the fraction of completely inaccessible particles.

One fitted D_{eff} reproduces each uptake curve



Across twenty beds, the mean fitted-curve NRMSE is 1.58%.

Per-bed optimization

1. solve the 1D model for a trial D
2. evaluate time-weighted NRMSE against the network curve
3. use previous errors to select the next D and repeat (optimization)

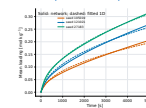
Solid: network.
Dashed: fitted 1D model.

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Results and robustness

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Per-bed optimization

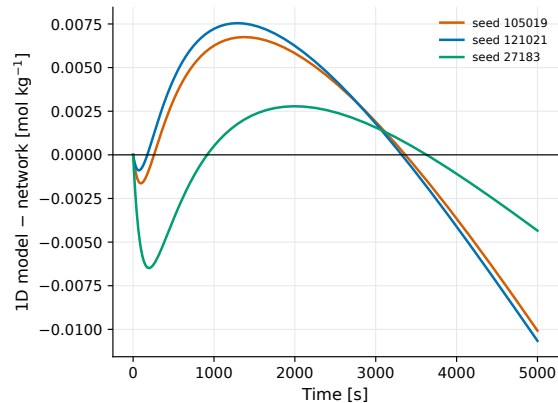
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Solid: network.
Dashed: fitted 1D model.

Across twenty beds, the mean fitted-curve NRMSE is 1.58%.

For each bed, the transient pore-network calculation provides a reference uptake curve. We repeatedly solve the 1D model with trial diffusivities and minimize the time-weighted normalized root-mean-square error. The bounded optimizer searches in $\log_{10} D$. Its initial trial follows from the prescribed bounds, without random sampling. Previous objective values guide subsequent trials until the search meets its tolerance. Each trial solves both coupled equations from the same initial state. The optimized diffusivity is D_{eff} . This figure shows per-bed fits, not predictions for unseen beds. The mean error is 1.58 percent.

Residuals show the remaining reduction error



Time-weighted NRMSE across all beds: 0.84–2.46%.

Curve residual

$$e(t) = \bar{q}_{1D}(t) - \bar{q}_{PNM}(t).$$

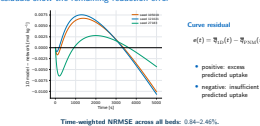
- positive: excess predicted uptake
- negative: insufficient predicted uptake

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Results and robustness

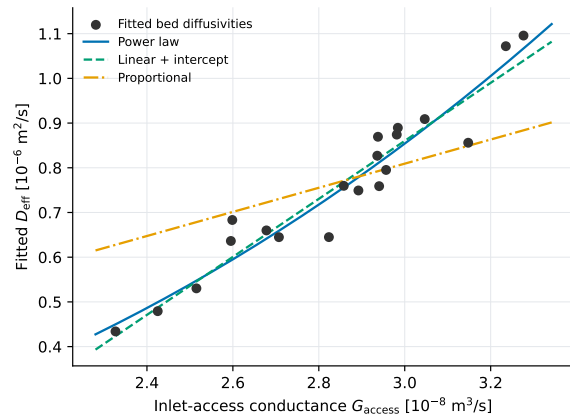
Residuals show the remaining reduction error

Residuals show the remaining reduction error



The same three representative beds appear here. The residual is the 1D mean loading minus the network mean loading. Its sign changes over time, showing that one coefficient cannot reproduce every detail. NRMSE summarizes the full residual curve using trapezoidal time weights and normalizes by final network loading.

Three relationships use the same inlet conductance



Predict D_{eff} from G_{access}

Proportional: $D_{\text{eff}} = \alpha_G G_{\text{access}}$

Linear: $D_{\text{eff}} = a_G G_{\text{access}} + b_G$

Power law: $D_{\text{eff}} = C_G G_{\text{access}}^n$

All coefficients are calibrated.
Their units make D_{eff} a diffusivity.

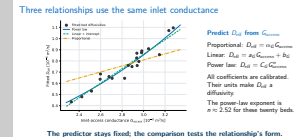
The power-law exponent is $n \approx 2.52$ for these twenty beds.

The predictor stays fixed; the comparison tests the relationship's form.

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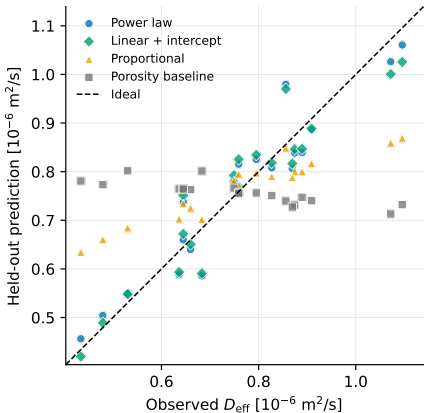
Results and robustness

Three relationships use the same inlet conductance



This figure uses raw inlet conductance for all three relationships. The proportional form has one coefficient. The linear and power-law forms have two. The power law is fitted by least squares in logarithmic coordinates, while linear and proportional fits use diffusivity coordinates; all held-out scores are then evaluated in physical diffusivity units. The fitted exponent is about 2.52. Coefficients carry the units required by the equations, so their numerical values depend on the unit convention. This full-ensemble plot illustrates the relationships, not their held-out accuracy. The power law is positive for positive conductance and approaches zero as conductance goes to zero. The linear fit has a negative intercept, so extrapolation outside the observed conductance range can become nonphysical. Neither form is established as universal.

Conductance predicts diffusivity for an omitted bed



Leave-one-bed-out comparison

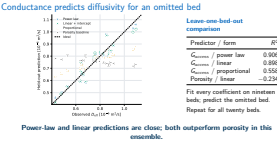
Predictor / form	R^2
G_{access} / power law	0.906
G_{access} / linear	0.898
G_{access} / proportional	0.558
Porosity / linear	-0.234

Fit every coefficient on nineteen beds; predict the omitted bed.
Repeat for all twenty beds.

Power-law and linear predictions are close; both outperform porosity in this ensemble.

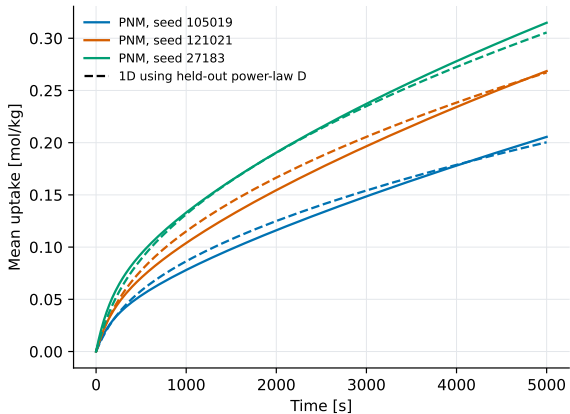
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- Results and robustness
 - Conductance predicts diffusivity for an omitted bed



All conductance-based forms now use the same G access predictor. We omit one bed, fit all coefficients to the other nineteen and predict the omitted fitted diffusivity. Power-law R squared is 0.906 and linear R squared is 0.898. This small difference does not establish decisive superiority. Proportionality gives 0.558 and the porosity baseline gives minus 0.234. The diffusivity target itself was obtained from the omitted PNM history; it is withheld from calibration of the relationship. Model form and depth were considered within this ensemble, so these scores are internal leave-one-bed-out validation, not independent validation of model selection. We next test the actual uptake histories generated from those predicted coefficients.

Predicted diffusivity reproduces the uptake history



Mean curve NRMSE, twenty beds

Relationship	Error
G_{access} / power law	2.61%
G_{access} / linear	2.64%
G_{access} / proportional	4.80%
Porosity / linear	7.58%

Use each held-out D_{eff} in the 1D solver, with no refitting.

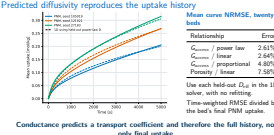
Time-weighted RMSE divided by the bed’s final PNM uptake.

Conductance predicts a transport coefficient and therefore the full history, not only final uptake.

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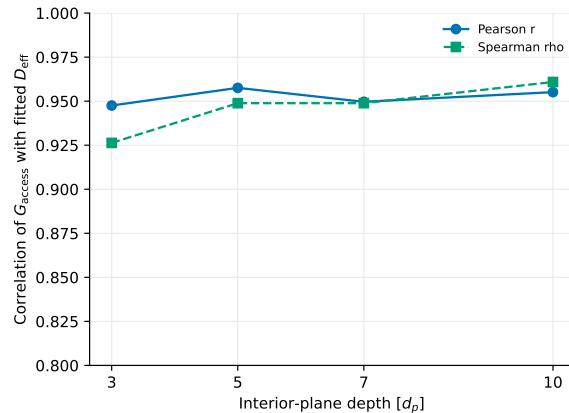
Results and robustness

Predicted diffusivity reproduces the uptake history



We now evaluate the end-to-end prediction. For each omitted bed, its predicted diffusivity is supplied to the same 100-cell 1D solver with the same material properties, inlet boundary, initial state, height and porosity as the original fit. We do not refit that coefficient to its uptake curve. All four relationships are propagated for all twenty beds, giving eighty simulations. The plotted solid curves are PNM references for low, median and high final uptake; dashed curves use held-out power-law predictions. The table reports the mean error across all twenty beds for every model. Curve NRMSE weights time by trapezoidal integration and divides by final reference uptake. Power law and linear give nearly identical mean errors, 2.61 and 2.64 percent. These include both coefficient prediction error and 1D reduction error. The earlier 1.58 percent measures the per-bed fitted reduction error and is a different quantity. G access can also be regressed directly against final uptake, but this route instead predicts D eff to obtain the complete transient response.

Conductance correlation across diagnostic depths



Depth sensitivity

- calculate G_{access} to planes at 3, 5, 7, $10d_p$
- Pearson: linear association
- Spearman: rank association

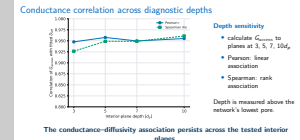
Depth is measured above the network's lowest pore.

The conductance–diffusivity association persists across the tested interior planes.

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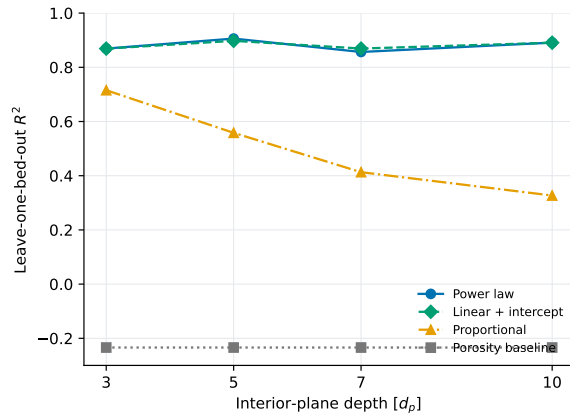
Results and robustness

Conductance correlation across diagnostic depths



This is the direct conductance descriptor, recalculated from the inlet to each of four interior planes. We compare each set of conductances with the same per-bed fitted effective diffusivities. Pearson measures linear association and Spearman measures monotonic rank association. The correlations remain high across these depths. This is an association check; the next slide refits and validates the predictive relationships at each depth.

Conductance-model performance across diagnostic depths



Four curves at every depth

$$D_{\text{eff}} = C_G G_{\text{access}}^n$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = a_G G_{\text{access}} + b_G$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = \alpha_G G_{\text{access}}$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = a_0 + a_1 \varepsilon_b$$

Refit on nineteen beds at each depth; predict the omitted bed.

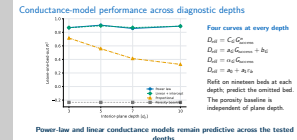
The porosity baseline is independent of plane depth.

Power-law and linear conductance models remain predictive across the tested depths.

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Results and robustness

Conductance-model performance across diagnostic depths



The figure contains four curves: power-law, linear-with-intercept and proportional relations using G_{access} , plus the porosity baseline. Every conductance relation is refitted within every leave-one-bed-out fold at each depth. The porosity curve stays constant because the predictor does not depend on the chosen plane. Five particle diameters gives the best power-law and linear score among these four planes for this ensemble. This establishes sensitivity within our existing data; it does not establish an optimal plane for other geometries or independently validate the model and depth choice. The normalized alternatives are kept in the separate optional appendix.

Section 5 of 5

Conclusions and next steps

What is established and what remains to validate

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What the present evidence establishes

Supported

- porosity alone misses important packing variability
- inlet-connected topology controls transient utilization
- one D_{eff} reproduces each detailed curve accurately
- G_{access} provides an interpretable predictive closure

Not yet claimed

- industrial breakthrough performance
- effects of flow, heat or water competition
- transfer to other bead sizes or D_{tube}/d_p
- a universal conductance–diffusivity relation

The contribution is a structure-to-model closure for a controlled diffusion-driven adsorption problem.

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└─ Conclusions and next steps

└─ What the present evidence establishes

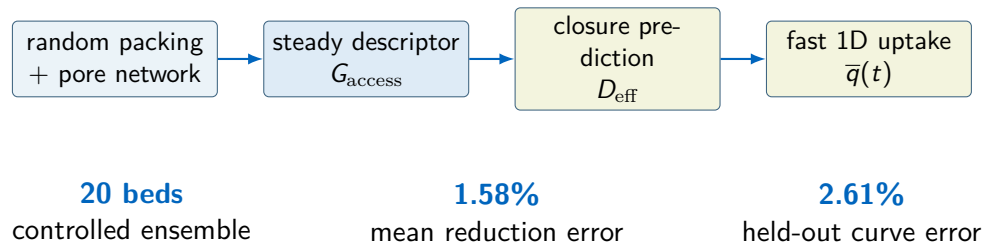
What the present evidence establishes

Supported	Not yet claimed
• porosity alone misses important packing variability • inlet-connected topology controls transient utilization • one D_{eff} reproduces each detailed curve accurately • G_{access} provides an interpretable predictive closure	• industrial breakthrough performance • effects of flow, heat or water competition • transfer to other bead sizes or D_{tube}/d_p • a universal conductance–diffusivity relation
The contribution is a structure-to-model closure for a controlled diffusion-driven adsorption problem.	

The evidence supports a steady inlet-conductance descriptor that captures transport differences missed by bulk porosity. A single fitted effective diffusivity reproduces each transient PNM curve with a mean error of 1.58 percent. Using conductance to predict that diffusivity gives a mean held-out curve error of 2.61 percent with the power law, essentially comparable to 2.64 percent for a linear model. The result is specific to this controlled diffusion-adsorption ensemble. We do not claim industrial breakthrough performance, robustness to heat or water competition, or transfer across bead sizes, tube geometries, sorbents and operating conditions. A more general study would be needed to establish those claims.

Pore accessibility retains what bulk porosity loses

Equal void volume does not imply equal transport. How that void space connects to the inlet matters.



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Conclusions and next steps

Pore accessibility retains what bulk porosity loses

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Equal void volume does not imply equal transport. How that void space connects to the inlet matters.



The central result is that inlet-connected gas conductance supplies information that porosity misses. Starting from a packing we calculate the network and its steady conductance, predict the effective diffusivity from a calibrated relationship, and run the homogeneous 1D transient model. The twenty-bed ensemble provides a fitted reduction error of 1.58 percent and a power-law held-out uptake-history error of 2.61 percent. These describe different steps in the workflow. The power-law diffusivity R squared is 0.906 and is close to the linear model score of 0.898. The aim is a simpler interpretable predictor for the controlled problem, not a claim of universal model superiority.

Pore-network geometry and throat diffusion

Network construction

- four bead centres define a Delaunay tetrahedron; its valid circumcentre represents a pore node
- tetrahedra sharing a triangular face are joined by a throat
- topology comes from particle coordinates, not voxels
- 2^{22} Sobol points sample the solid and gas space.
- Gas-point counts allocate the calculated void volume to pores.

The circular throat area is a geometric modelling assumption; G_{ij} has units of $\text{m}^3 \text{s}^{-1}$.

Diffusion through throat $i-j$

$$G_{ij} = D_m \frac{A_{ij}}{L_{ij}}, \quad \dot{n}_{ij} = G_{ij}(c_j - c_i).$$

$D_m = 1.5 \times 10^{-5} \text{ m}^2 \text{s}^{-1}$: molecular CO_2 diffusivity in the gas.

$L_{ij} = \|\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\|$ is the pore-centre distance. The irregular opening between three beads is approximated by an equivalent circular area

$$A_{ij} = \pi r_{ij}^2,$$

where r_{ij} is the clearance of the shared Delaunay face.

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

└ Pore-network geometry and throat diffusion

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The particle centres define Delaunay tetrahedra. Valid circumcentres become pore nodes, and a shared triangular face defines a candidate throat. We do not explicitly reconstruct the full three-dimensional geometry of each pore body. Instead, we associate a control volume with each pore node. To estimate these pore volumes, we sample 2^{22} Sobol points in the cylindrical bed domain. Sobol points form a low-discrepancy quasi-random sequence, so they fill the domain more uniformly than ordinary random sampling. Each sample is first classified as solid or void. Every void-space sample is then assigned to its nearest pore centre. The fraction of void samples assigned to each pore provides its relative pore volume, and the resulting volumes are normalized so that their sum equals the analytically calculated total void volume of the bed. $D_{\text{sub } m}$ is the prescribed molecular diffusivity of CO_2 in the gas, 1.5 times ten to the minus five square metres per second. It is a fixed model input, not the fitted bed-scale effective diffusivity. Conductance equals this diffusivity times the approximate throat opening area divided by the pore-centre distance. The throat geometry is therefore treated separately from the pore-body volume allocation. Detailed construction sketches remain in the optional appendix.

The pore network solves diffusion and adsorption together

Gas balance for each pore i

$$V_i \frac{dc_i}{dt} = \sum_{j \in \mathcal{N}(i)} G_{ij}(c_j - c_i) + G_{iR}(c_R - c_i) - S_i.$$

- V_i : gas volume, c_i : gas concentration
- G_{ij} : throat conductance [$\text{m}^3 \text{s}^{-1}$]
- G_{iR} : connection to reservoir at c_R , zero away from the inlet
- S_i : net gas transfer to adjacent beads [mol s^{-1}]

Uptake for each bead k

$$\frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{\text{LDF}}(q_k^* - q_k).$$

- q_k : current loading [mol kg^{-1}]
- k_{LDF} [s^{-1}]: linear-driving-force rate coefficient
- $1/k_{\text{LDF}}$: relaxation time at fixed gas concentration

One coupled system: one concentration per pore and one loading per bead.

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One coupled system: one concentration per pore and one loading per bead.

This is the transient diffusion equation on the network, expressed as a balance on each pore volume. The first term exchanges gas with neighbouring pores, the second connects inlet pores to the finite-conductance reservoir, and the final term transfers gas to beads. Each bead has one loading equation even if several pores surround it. LDF means linear driving force: the rate is proportional to the difference between equilibrium and current loading. All pore concentrations and bead loadings are integrated together from the prescribed initial state as one coupled transient system. Numerically, the system is solved with an implicit BDF time integrator. This is suitable for a stiff diffusion–adsorption system, where fast and slow time scales coexist. The solver uses adaptive time stepping and changes the step size automatically to satisfy the prescribed relative and absolute error tolerances. The total transfer satisfies $\sum_i S_i = \sum_k m_k dq_k/dt$, so adsorption transfers gas into the solid inventory. In the code, positive uptake is allocated among incident pores using incidence weights multiplied by positive gas concentration, preventing empty pores from supplying gas. Desorption uses normalized incidence weights. No independent gas-flow or pressure equation is solved.

Local equilibrium sets the adsorption target

Local equilibrium loading

$$p_k = c_k R T, \quad q_k^* = \frac{q_s b p_k}{1 + b p_k}.$$

- c_k : average gas concentration around bead k
- p_k : local CO₂ partial pressure [Pa]
- q_k^* : equilibrium target [mol kg⁻¹]

Fixed material parameters

- q_s : maximum CO₂ loading [mol kg⁻¹]
- b : Langmuir affinity [Pa⁻¹], so $b p_k$ is dimensionless
- k_{LDF} : kinetic coefficient [s⁻¹]

Actual loading evolves in time

$$\frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{\text{LDF}}(q_k^* - q_k).$$

Local gas concentrations set the target. Kinetics determine how quickly beads approach it.

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

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Local equilibrium loading $p_k = c_k R T, \quad q_k^* = \frac{q_s b p_k}{1 + b p_k}$ • c_k: average gas concentration around bead k • p_k: local CO₂ partial pressure [Pa] • q_k^*: equilibrium target [mol kg⁻¹]	Fixed material parameters • q_s: maximum CO₂ loading [mol kg⁻¹] • b: Langmuir affinity [Pa⁻¹], so $b p_k$ is dimensionless • k_{LDF}: kinetic coefficient [s⁻¹] Actual loading evolves in time $\frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{\text{LDF}}(q_k^* - q_k).$ Local gas concentrations set the target. Kinetics determine how quickly beads approach it.

The local gas concentration around bead k is a normalized, pore-volume-weighted average over its associated pores. The implementation uses nonnegative concentrations in this calculation. The ideal-gas relation gives the local CO₂ partial pressure and the Langmuir isotherm supplies the equilibrium loading. This equilibrium target is not a new differential unknown. The actual loading evolves through the LDF equation introduced on the preceding slide. The parameter q_s is the saturation, or maximum, CO₂ loading of the zeolite according to the Langmuir model; in this work we use $q_s = 5.332$ mol kg⁻¹. It is the asymptotic loading approached at sufficiently high CO₂ partial pressure, not the actual loading reached at every operating condition. The saturation loading and affinity are prescribed material parameters, and k_{LDF} is fixed across packings. Adsorption removes gas from the incident pores and adds it to the bead, preserving the combined inventory apart from reservoir exchange.

The pore network delivers the reference uptake curve

Resolved transient outputs

- Gas concentration $c_i(t)$ in every pore
- Adsorbed loading $q_k(t)$ of every bead
- Different bead loadings reveal incomplete utilization

The detailed model retains the actual pore connections and bead associations.

Bed-average uptake

$$\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t) = \frac{\sum_k m_k q_k(t)}{\sum_k m_k}.$$

For identical beads:

$$\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t) = \frac{1}{N_b} \sum_{k=1}^{N_b} q_k(t).$$

This curve is the reference for fitting the reduced 1D model.

Next: can a homogeneous 1D bed reproduce this complete uptake curve?

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

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Next: can a homogeneous 1D bed reproduce this complete uptake curve?

The network calculation produces many concentration and loading histories. For model reduction, we summarize the adsorbed inventory as the mass-weighted mean loading of all beads. Because the beads have equal masses, this is their arithmetic mean. We retain the full time series, not only the final loading. The PNM curve is a numerical reference under our modelling assumptions, not an experimental measurement. We now ask whether a much smaller homogeneous model can reproduce this curve.

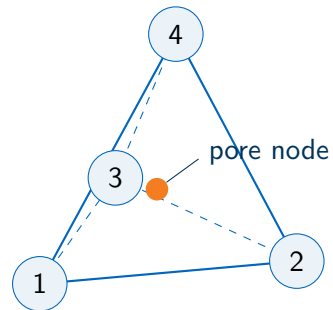
Backup slides

How the pore network is constructed

Particle geometry, Sobol volume allocation and transport

These supplementary slides explain the construction in the code. The sketches illustrate the method and are not extracted simulation geometries.

1. Particle positions define candidate pore nodes



Schematic 3D projection
Bead centres form a tetrahedron

- Start with known bead centres, radii and bed boundaries.
- Delaunay tetrahedralization groups neighbouring centres into sets of four.
- Locate the circumcentre: the point equidistant from those four centres.
- Retain valid points inside the bed and outside the solid as pore nodes.

A node represents a gas region. Its volume is assigned later.

The particle geometry determines where the pore nodes are placed.

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Backup: pore-network construction

1. Particle positions define candidate pore nodes

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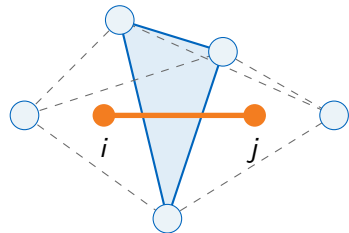
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A node represents a gas region. Its volume is assigned later.

The particle geometry determines where the pore nodes are placed.

Our beads have equal radii, so ordinary Delaunay geometry is used. The sketch is a projected tetrahedron. Its drawn pore marker is illustrative. The actual code computes each circumcentre in three dimensions, rejects singular tetrahedra and checks the point against the bed domain and bead surfaces. A pore node is a representative location rather than a reconstructed cavity surface.

2. Shared particle faces define pore connections



Two tetrahedra share three beads
Schematic 3D projection

- Two neighbouring tetrahedra share a triangular face.
- The three beads around that face define an opening.
- A valid opening connects pore nodes i and j through a throat.
- Estimate throat length L_{ij} and circular area A_{ij} from geometry.

$$G_{ij} = D_m \frac{A_{ij}}{L_{ij}}.$$

At this stage we know the nodes and connections. Sobol sampling has not been used.

2026-09-23

└ Backup: pore-network construction

└ 2. Shared particle faces define pore connections

The code uses shared Delaunay faces to identify candidate throats. Length is the distance between pore nodes. The throat radius is approximated by the shared-face circumradius minus the bead radius, and the area by pi times radius squared. Closed or degenerate connections are rejected. This circular opening is a modelling approximation, not the exact three-sphere aperture.

2. Shared particle faces define pore connections



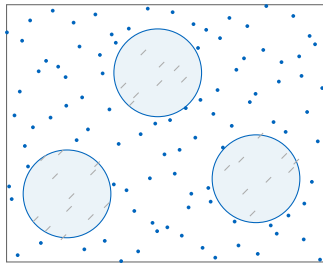
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At this stage we know the nodes and connections. Sobol sampling has not been used.

3. Sobol points measure the gas space



Illustrative 2D Sobol sample

Blue: gas points; grey crosses: solid points

- Distribute $2^{22} \approx 4.2$ million sample points through the cylindrical bed.
- Sobol sampling covers the domain with few gaps and clusters.
- Check each point against the bead surfaces.
- Discard points inside solid particles and retain gas-space points.

These are measuring points, not extra pores or mesh cells.

Sobol sampling estimates volume. It does not generate network connections.

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

└ 3. Sobol points measure the gas space

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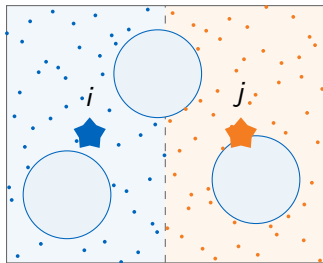
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These are measuring points, not extra pores or mesh cells.
Sobol sampling estimates volume. It does not generate network connections.

The actual code generates a scrambled three-dimensional Sobol sequence and maps it uniformly into the cylinder. The sketch uses a two-dimensional Sobol sequence only to explain solid versus void classification. The points do not carry concentration or take part in the time integration. Increasing the sample count improves the volume estimates while leaving the geometry-derived graph unchanged.

4. Assign gas-space samples to the nearest pore



Two illustrative pore nodes
Each gas point takes its nearest node's colour

- Assign every retained gas point to its nearest pore node.
- Count the assigned points: N_i for pore i .
- A larger count gives a larger share of the calculated void volume.

$$V_i = V_{\text{void}} \frac{N_i + 0.5}{\sum_j (N_j + 0.5)}.$$

- The small 0.5 correction prevents zero volumes.
- Normalization ensures $\sum_i V_i = V_{\text{void}}$.

The total volume is conserved, while each individual pore volume is an estimate.

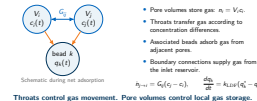


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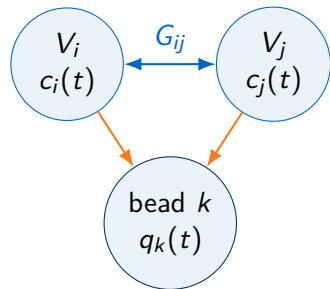
The total volume is conserved, while each individual pore volume is an estimate.

The dashed line illustrates a nearest-node partition for two nodes in two dimensions. The actual allocation uses all retained nodes in three dimensions and Euclidean nearest-neighbour distances. Total void volume is calculated independently from cylinder volume minus the calculated solid volume within the bed bounds. It is not taken directly from the fraction of Sobol points in gas. Normalization fixes the total but does not prove the local volumes are exact or boundary-conforming.



The particle-pore association comes from the tetrahedral geometry. Once geometry, volumes and boundary conditions are known, the solver advances pore concentrations and bead loadings together. Gas removed by adsorption is added to the solid inventory. During desorption the exchange reverses. This construction describes the gas space between beads; bead uptake kinetics represent the internal adsorption process.

5. The network carries coupled diffusion and adsorption



Schematic during net adsorption

- Pore volumes store gas: $n_i = V_i c_i$.
- Throats transfer gas according to concentration differences.
- Associated beads adsorb gas from adjacent pores.
- Boundary connections supply gas from the inlet reservoir.

$$\dot{n}_{j \rightarrow i} = G_{ij}(c_j - c_i), \quad \frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{LDF}(q_k^* - q_k).$$

Throats control gas movement. Pore volumes control local gas storage.

Reduce the detailed network to a homogeneous 1D bed

Detailed pore-network model

- Actual pores and throats from each packing
- One gas concentration per pore
- One loading per bead
- Reference mean uptake $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$

Homogeneous 1D model

- Replace the network by 100 equal axial slices
- Each slice spans the full tube cross-section
- One gas concentration and one mean solid loading per slice
- Represent unresolved pathways with a single diffusivity D

Fit D so the reduced model reproduces the network's mean uptake history.

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└ Backup: homogeneous 1D model

└ Reduce the detailed network to a homogeneous 1D bed

Reduce the detailed network to a homogeneous 1D bed

Detailed pore-network model

- Actual pores and throats from each packing
- One gas concentration per pore
- One loading per bead
- Reference mean uptake $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$

Homogeneous 1D model

- Replace the network by 100 equal axial slices
- Each slice spans the full tube cross-section
- One gas concentration and one mean solid loading per slice
- Represent unresolved pathways with a single diffusivity D

Fit D so the reduced model reproduces the network's mean uptake history.

The one-dimensional cells do not come from the pore-network extraction. We create a separate grid by dividing bed height into one hundred equal slices spanning the tube cross-section. Each slice contains homogenized gas and adsorbent phases. The detailed pore paths disappear from this representation. Their impact on transient uptake is represented by one fitted diffusivity. The reduced system has two hundred concentration and loading states, while the PNM has a state for every pore and bead. We compare their mean uptake curves rather than attempting a one-to-one mapping of their internal fields.

The homogeneous 1D uptake model

Gas balance in each axial cell

$$\varepsilon_b \frac{\partial c}{\partial t} = D \frac{\partial^2 c}{\partial z^2} - (1 - \varepsilon_b) \rho_p \frac{\partial q}{\partial t}.$$

Adsorbent loading in each axial cell

$$\frac{\partial q}{\partial t} = k_{\text{LDF}} \left[\frac{q_s b R T c}{1 + b R T c} - q \right].$$

- Divide the bed height into 100 equal slices, each spanning the tube cross-section.
- Solve gas concentration and mean solid loading together in each slice.
- Trial D changes c , which changes adsorption.

ε_b : **bed porosity, uniform in all 100 cells of each bed.**

Average the calculated loading

$$\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D) = \frac{1}{H} \int_0^H q(z, t; D) dz.$$

For 100 equal axial cells:

$$\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D) = \frac{1}{100} \sum_{\ell=1}^{100} q_{\ell}(t; D).$$

- Match bed height, porosity and inlet condition to the network.
- Keep isotherm, kinetics and initial state fixed. Only D changes.

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└ Backup: homogeneous 1D model

└ The homogeneous 1D uptake model

This slide describes the homogeneous one-dimensional model, not the individual pore network. Each axial cell contains gas and a homogenized amount of adsorbent. Epsilon b is the dimensionless bed void fraction, not bulk density. It is uniform over all 100 cells and constant in time, but differs slightly between packings. The mass of adsorbent per bed volume is one minus epsilon b, multiplied by the apparent bead density rho p. We solve one gas concentration and one solid loading per cell, giving 200 coupled state equations for 100 cells. The loading equation explicitly substitutes the Langmuir equilibrium relation and p equals cRT. The diffusivity appears in the gas balance. Changing it changes the gas concentration history and therefore the adsorption history. The right-hand side is a spatial average of the calculated loadings, not an additional independent evolution equation. For equal cells and uniform adsorbent density, the arithmetic average is the bed mean loading.

The homogeneous 1D uptake model

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